neighbour in the Indian Ocean Region (IOR) and occupies a special place in the Modi government's Neighbourhood First policy. In recent years, India has invested hugely in the island nation, located around 70 nautical miles from Minicoy in Lakshadweep and around 300 nautical miles from India's west coast. India's engagement with Male has a strategic element to it, and is part of its geopolitical contest with China, as Beijing seeks to wind its tentacles across the IOR. However, the Muizzu regime's 'India Out' policy is seen as a setback for New Delhi. After asking Indian soldiers to leave, Muizzu's government decided not to renew the agreement with the Indian navy for a hydrographic survey of Maldivian waters in December 2023. The announcement came when Beijing was allowed to dock its 'research survey vessel' in the Maldives for conducting deep-water exploration. New Delhi is suspicious about snooping by similar Chinese 'research' vessels on Indian defence bases.

THE MALDIVIAN MINISTERS' ATTACK ON INDIA HAS SPARKED A 'BOYCOTT MALDIVES' CAMPAIGN

India needs to play a fine balancing game with the Maldives. Experts caution that the current controversy should not descend into a Hindu-Muslim fracas or an anti-China rant, pushing the president further into the arms of Beijing. There is a larger Indian Ocean game—where China seems to be getting ahead—that India should keep in mind. Experts say while it is good to bare its teeth, India should not push the episode to breaking point. Instead, it should use it as a leverage to keep Muizzu on the backfoot and work through backchannels to further Indian interests there. ■

INDIA-FRANCE

The French Consolidation



MAKING WAVES PM Modi with President Macron of France in Paris, July 14, 2023 AP

By Pradip R. Sagar

As befits a 'true friend', French president Emmanuel Macron has come to India's rescue after the US indicated that President Joe Biden would not be able to attend India's 75th Republic Day celebrations in 2024 as chief guest. PM Narendra Modi had invited Biden for the event on the sidelines of the G20 summit in September last year. "Thank you for your invitation, my dear friend @NarendraModi. India, on your Republic Day, I'll be here to celebrate with you!" Macron wrote on X. In a prompt response, PM Modi wrote, "My Dear Friend President @EmmanuelMacron, we eagerly look forward to receiving you as the Chief Guest at the 75th Republic Day. We will also celebrate India-France's strategic partnership and shared belief in democratic values. Bientôt !"

Macron's presence will mark the sixth time that a French leader has been chief guest on Republic Day—the most from any country. In July, PM Modi was guest of honour at the Bastille Day parade in Paris. Macron had bestowed the Grand Cross of the Legion of Honour—France's highest civilian/ military honour—on Modi.

All this demonstrative warmth in ties serves as a marker of a rather significant shift—Paris is on its way to replacing Russia as the biggest source of military hardware for New Delhi. Currently, France is India's second-largest weapons supplier, with a 29 per cent share after Russia (45 per cent) and surpassing the US (11 per cent), according to a March 2023 report by the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute. Like Russia, France is supplying fighter jets to submarines to the Indian military, apart from other sub-systems.

Macron's visit comes at a time when the two nations are about to sign two major defence deals. The first is for 26 Rafale Marine jets for the Indian navy's aircraft carriers INS *Vikrant* and INS *Vikramaditya* and the second is for three additional